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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Head Start providers and families fear Trump years

Federal actions create uncertainty for free preschool program

By Kate Armanini
Chicago Tribune

Two-year-old Cassidy Reed awoke quickly from her afternoon nap. She bounded across the colorful, toy-strewn preschool to babble with four other toddlers at a miniature table.

"She just loves it," her great-grandmother, Rochelle Simeon, said with a smile. "I have a hard time getting her out of here." Simeon, 72, is the adoptive mother of Cassidy, her twin brother, Brandon, and their 3-year-old sister, Kayle. All three attend the Mitzi Freidheim Englewood Child and Family Center through Head Start, the federal early education program for low-income children.

The free preschool is a lifeline to Simeon as she navigates parent-

hood later in life. She takes comfort in the familiar building, the teachers and the quality of care — it's the same center her grandson attended nearly two decades ago. The employees feel like family, she said.

But the past 10 months under President Donald Trump's administration have cast a cloud of uncertainty over Head Start. A series of federal actions threatened to

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Karriem Muhammed hugs Marina Lovato, who specializes in inclusion for students with specialized needs, on Oct. 15 at the Mitzi Freidheim Child Center in Chicago. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



Birds fly over a mostly empty Swap-O-Rama market Tuesday in the Back of the Yards neighborhood of Chicago after 13 people were detained in an immigration raid the previous week. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

The easiest targets

Gig workers, street vendors and day laborers have been hit by feds in Chicago immigration crackdown

By Talia Soglin
Chicago Tribune

Five days after armed federal agents descended on the Swap-O-Rama flea market and took more than a dozen people away, some of the market's vendors were back at work, selling tools, hot sauce and women's underwear from spaces they rent in the parking lot.

But the flea market was mostly barren on Tuesday's overcast afternoon. Customers and vendors alike, it seemed, were staying away.

"It's a hard decision," to set up shop again at the open-air Back of

the Yards market, said one Swap-O-Rama vendor, who gave only her first name, Sylvia. "We don't like what happened last Thursday, but we have to come."

Weeks into President Donald Trump's immigration crackdown in Chicago, that's a decision some of Chicago's most vulnerable workers — those who work out in the open, selling tamales on street corners and waiting for construction jobs outside home improvement stores — are making every day.

Over the last seven weeks, federal agents have carried out several raids in a parking lot near

O'Hare International Airport where ride-share drivers wait for passengers. They arrested a flower seller in Archer Heights and another street vendor as she sold tamales outside a Home Depot in Back of the Yards. On Wednesday, they detained a cotton candy vendor near 28th Street in Little Village. They detained 13 people at Swap-O-Rama.

So far, large-scale worksite immigration raids, the likes of which were more common during the first Trump administration and for which workers and their advocates have prepared since the beginning of

Immigration agents detained two Aurora protesters who confronted them, sparking claims of unnecessary force. **Page 4**

this year, have largely not materialized in Chicago, although the administration has carried them out elsewhere. Instead, many of those being detained have been gig workers or those working independently, particularly those who work outside. Administration officials say they have arrested more than 1,500 people during

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US, China close to finalizing trade deal

Trump, Xi prepare for meeting this week in SKorea

By Chris Megerian,
David Rising
and Eileen Ng
Associated Press

KUALA LUMPUR, Malaysia — A trade deal between the United States and China is drawing closer, officials from the world's two largest economies said Sunday as they reached an initial consensus for President Donald Trump and Chinese leader Xi Jinping to aim to finalize during their high-stakes meeting while Trump is in Asia.

Any agreement would be a relief to international markets even if it does not address underlying issues involving manufacturing imbalances and access to state-of-the-art computer chips.

Beijing recently limited exports of rare earth elements needed for advanced technologies, and Trump responded by threatening additional tariffs on Chinese products. The prospect of a widening conflict risks weakening economic growth worldwide.

China's top trade negotiator, Li Chenggang, told reporters that the two sides had reached a "preliminary consensus," while U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said there was "a very successful framework."

Trump also expressed confidence that an agreement was at hand, saying the Chinese "want to make a deal and we want to make a deal." The president is set to meet with Xi on Thursday in South Korea, the final stop of his trip through Asia.

Bessent told CBS's "Face the Nation" that the threat of additional higher tariffs on China was "effectively off the table."

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INSIDE

Rogers Park tenants union OKs rent strike

The group representing 150 residents in four buildings slammed a new landlord's rent hike and joined calls for a blanket moratorium on evictions. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

USDA says SNAP benefits will not go out Saturday

The agency's notice about food aid on its website raises the stakes for families nationwide as the government shutdown drags on. **Nation & World**

Ambitious plan reconnects river to floodplain



Randy Smith, Illinois River Project director, talks about the status of the project on the marsh at The Nature Conservancy's Emiquon Nature Preserve on Oct. 9. **DARYL WILSON/FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Emiquon Nature Preserve in central Illinois becomes stage for major restoration

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

In the shadow of an imposing 27-foot earthen levee, a coyote slinks through tallgrass prairie. American coots, mallards and great blue herons dart around a shallow lake peppered with the flowers of the American lotus and flanked by the Illinois River.

The river was once one of the most ecologically and economically significant river systems in North America, supporting inland commercial

fisheries and the continent's highest mussel abundance. Emiquon Nature Preserve, 40 miles southwest of Peoria in central Illinois, offers a small glimpse into that past.

Outside the 6,000-acre preserve, the landscape starkly changes from brush to massive fields of corn and soybeans.

In the early 20th century, wetlands were drained for agriculture and disconnected from the thriving river and its adjacent low-lying land or floodplain — which was then farmed "intensively," according to Randy Smith, Illinois rivers program director at The Nature Conservancy. "The whole site would have looked like that prior to restoration," he said,

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